true, and mathematical" space in itself, which exists even where there is nothing.

The difference between Aristotle and Newton is glaring. For Newton, between two things there may also be "empty space." For Aristotle, it is absurd to speak of "empty" space, because space is only the spatial order of things. If there are no things—their extension, their contacts—there is no space. Newton imagines that things are situated in a "space" that continues to exist, empty, even when divested of things. For Aristotle, this "empty space" is nonsensical, because if two things do not touch it means that there is something else between them, and if there is something, then this something is a thing, and therefore a thing that is there. It cannot be that there is "nothing."

For my part, I find it curious that both these ways of thinking about space originate from our everyday experience. The difference between them exists due to a quirky accident of the world in which we live: the lightness of air, the presence of which we only barely perceive. We can say: I see a table, a chair, a pen, the ceiling—and that between myself and the table *there is nothing*. Or we can say that between one and another of these things *there is air*. Sometimes we speak of air as if it were something, sometimes as if it were nothing. Sometimes as if it were there, sometimes as if it were not there. We are used to saying "This glass is empty" in order to say that it is full of air. We can consequently think of the world around us as "almost empty," with just a few objects here and there, or alternatively as "completely full" of air. In the end, Aristotle and Newton do not engage in profound metaphysics: they are only using these two different intuitive and ingenious ways of seeing the world around us—taking or not taking air into account—and transforming them into definitions of space.

Aristotle, always top of the class, wants to be precise: he does not say that the glass is empty; he says that it is full of air. And he remarks that, in our experience, there is never a place where "there is nothing, not even air." Newton, looking not so much for accuracy as for efficiency of the conceptual paradigm that needs to be constructed in order to describe the movement of things, thinks not about air but about objects. Air, after all, seems to have little effect on a falling stone. We can imagine that it is not even there.

As in the case of time, Newton's "container space" may seem natural to us, but it is a recent idea that has spread due to the enormous influence of his thought. That which seems intuitive to us now is the result of scientific and philosophical elaborations in the past.

The Newtonian idea of "empty space" seems to be confirmed when Torricelli demonstrates that it is possible to remove the air from a bottle. It